

Ecuador



Area 109,483 sq miles
(283,590 sq km)
Population 14.7 million
Capital Quito
Currency US dollar
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 75 years



Located on the continent's west coast, Ecuador is one of the smallest countries in South America. The volcanic Galápagos Islands in the Pacific Ocean are also a part of Ecuador. Most Ecuadorians live either in the lowland coastal region called Costa or

in the Andean Sierra highlands. Many of the world's bananas are grown in the Costa region, making Ecuador the biggest exporter of bananas. Another main source of income is from oil drilling around the Amazon Basin. This, however, has had a negative effect on the environment and on the indigenous tribes living in the area.

► GALÁPAGOS WILDLIFE

The great frigate bird, native to the Galápagos Islands, puffs out its inflatable throat pouch to attract mates during the breeding season.



Bolivia



Area 424,164 sq miles
(1,098,580 sq km)
Population 10.1 million
Capital Sucre and La Paz
Currency Boliviano
Official languages Spanish, Quechua, and Aymara
Life expectancy 65 years



A landlocked nation, Bolivia lies in the central part of South America. It has two capitals—Sucre is the judicial capital, while La Paz is the administrative capital. La Paz, at 11,975 ft (3,650 m) above sea level, is the highest capital city in the world. Bolivia is home to the world's highest golf course, ski run, and soccer stadium.

Colombia



Area 430,736 sq miles
(1,138,910 sq km)
Population 46.9 million
Capital Bogotá
Currency Colombian peso
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 73 years



Colombia is in northwest South America, where the continent connects with Central and North America. A land of extremes, Colombia has snow-covered mountains, tropical beaches, deserts, and grasslands called Los Llanos. Colombia sits on the Pacific Ring of Fire, and has many volcanoes and frequent earthquakes.

Venezuela



Area 352,144 sq miles
(912,050 sq km)
Population 29.4 million
Capital Caracas
Currency Bolívar fuerte
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 74 years



With a long Caribbean coastline, the Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela is part of northern South America. Venezuela has some of the largest known oil deposits outside the Middle East. Though it is one of the most urbanized societies in South America, extreme poverty still exists in the *barrios*, or shantytowns, on the hillsides.

Peru



Area 496,218 sq miles
(1,285,200 sq km)
Population 29.4 million
Capital Lima
Currency Nuevo sol
Official languages Spanish and Quechua
Life expectancy 71 years



Lying just south of the equator, on the Pacific coast of South America, is the Republic of Peru. It is the third largest South American country, after Brazil and Argentina. Most Peruvians are of mixed cultures, including Amerindian, European, African, and Asian. Peru's varied landscape can be divided into three regions—

the coast, the mountains, and the rainforests. The arid Pacific coast is where all the major cities, including the capital city of Lima, are located. This area is home to about half of Peru's population. From the coastal plains rise the Andes mountains, dominated in the south by volcanoes. The east of the country contains Amazon rainforests. These dense forests are home to many unique species of plants and animals. Peru is rich in natural resources—gold, silver, copper, zinc, lead, and iron are found across the country. However, Peru remains one of the poorest nations in the world, with about 40 percent of the population living below the poverty line.



▲ MACHU PICCHU

A UNESCO World Heritage site, the historic city of Machu Picchu is nestled on a hilltop in the Andes mountains. It was built by the Inca people around 600 years ago.